

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 106

Culture (OWC): [Ovambo \(FX08\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1947-1948

Coverage Date: 1947 AD - 1948 AD

Place Coverage: Cunene Province, Angola

Section Title(S): Kinship Customs .

The Kuanyama mother-in-law taboo is an avoidance relationship which I have described elsewhere.¹¹ A man never sits on the ground with his mother-in-law or eats with her. He averts his eyes in shame when speaking to her. A young married woman is bashful in the presence of her husband's father; a young married man, in the presence of his wife's mother. A man also casts down his eyes when talking to his future father-in-law.

113
[Bibliographies In Sources](#)

593
[Family Relationships](#)

784
[Avoidance And Taboo](#)

A man or a woman considers the tatekulu (mother's brother) his or her best friend. A boy constantly makes small gifts to his tatekulu and expects to inherit from him. A tatekulu may always moreover be depended on to furnish shelter to his nephew or his niece in time of need. Usually it is their mother's eldest brother who thus protects them.

572
[Friendships](#)

576
[Etiquette](#)

593
[Family Relationships](#)

The father's sister is not considered a female father as in some African tribes and has no special function in the family life of the Kuanyama.

171
[Comparative Evidence](#)

593
[Family Relationships](#)

890
[Gender Roles And Issues](#)

Kuanyama brothers and sisters are very close to one another, and a number of stories have been collected which show that they owe one another protection. It is considered improper for a man to engage in sexual conversation in front of his sister.

593
Family Relationships

784
Avoidance And Taboo

A man is on intimate terms with his haukue, his brothers-in-law and sisters-in-law, and they are always welcome if they wish to live in his kraal. But there are no joking relationships between relatives by marriage, even if they are of opposite sexes. A man never marries his father's widow, but he may marry his brother's widow if he wishes. Usually he does so "to help out," that is, to provide for the widow.¹² A man never marries mother and daughter at the same time, or two sisters. If his wife dies, however, he may marry her younger sister.

522
Humor

582
Regulation Of Marriage

593
Family Relationships

601
Kinship Terminology

602
Kin Relationships

784
Avoidance And Taboo

The Kuanyama maintain relationships between cousins, both parallel and cross-cousins. For example, the ceremonial relationship between parallel cousins, the children of two brothers, is expressed in the "heart feast" (omitima),¹³ one of the great feasts of the Kuanyama and one enjoyed in both past and present times. Christians as well as pagans give it, for it involves no sacrifices to ancestors. The conduct of the feast is as follows:

574
Visiting And Hospitality

602
Kin Relationships

605
Cousins

769
Cult Of The Dead

When a man of the Cattle Clan kills an ox, he holds a feast. If he has a male parallel cousin, for example his father's brother's son, who also belongs to the Cattle Clan, this cousin is invited to the feast and is entitled to the ox's heart. If the host has no male cousin on his father's side a female parallel cousin belonging to the Cattle Clan may be invited. Usually, in fact, it is a woman rather than a man who comes to claim the heart, probably because a woman is more able to give a feast in return and because the women outnumber the men on the Reserve. The female cousin arrives on the appointed day, carrying a basket, and collects the heart of the slaughtered ox, the lungs, and the throat. After sharing the feast, she takes these parts back to her kraal.

574
Visiting And Hospitality

602
Kin Relationships

605
Cousins

11. Loeb, 1948, p. 28.

12. If the deceased had no child, the first child born to the widow is called "son" (daughter) of X, the deceased.

13. The general word for a feast is otendale.

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)